

Lecture 3

Summary Handout

Understanding the Inner You: The Science of Personality

This lecture aims to provide an overview about personality, which is the key characteristics that help distinguish individuals from one another. Examples of personality classification will be provided as well as theoretical grounds that help explain personality development.

Personality Defined

Personality refers to personal tendencies in the individuals' thinking, feeling, and behavior. Altogether, these tendencies help distinguish individuals from one another. While they are not totally fixed as they could be impacted by situational constraints, these characteristics are relatively stable and could be predictive of our responses in a given situation.

Examples of Personality Classification

There are various dimensions of personality; and attempts have been made to classify key personality dimensions. Among the well-recognized classifications is the Big-5 Personality (Costa & McCrae, 1976), which will be used for the self-assessment here. Based on the Big-5 classification, personality can be divided into five dimensions of:

Extraversion: This dimension reflects the degree to which individuals are oriented toward social interaction and external activities. Individuals high in this dimension exhibit preferences for social interactions and are frequently perceived as energetic and action-oriented.

Agreeableness: This dimension reflects the degree to which individuals are oriented toward social harmony. Individuals high in this dimension value getting along with others and are generally perceived as trustful, compassionate, and cooperative.

Neuroticism: This dimension reflects the sensitivity and vulnerability toward psychological distresses. Individuals high in this dimension could be emotionally reactive and experience psychological distress.

Conscientiousness: This dimension reflects the orientation toward self-discipline, dutifulness, and achievement orientation. Individuals high in this dimension are generally perceived as highly responsible, efficient, and reliable.

Openness to Experience: This dimension reflects the degree to which individuals are willing to go beyond their comfort zone, to experience new things, and to be curious

about ideas, imaginations, and emotional experiences. Individuals high in this dimension are generally perceived as adventurous, creative, and unconventional.

Past studies have demonstrated the associations between some personality dimensions and adjustment/well-being. For example, a positive association between extraversion and adjustment/well-being for gregariousness could help increase opportunities for ones to cultivate social relationships, and thus attain social support. In contrast, neuroticism has been shown to be negatively associated with adjustment/well-being. Extreme orientations toward certain personality dimensions, or a lack thereof, could interfere with ones' adjustments. For example, extreme needs for social stimulations are less likely to be fulfilled. Too much conscientiousness could lead to stress and undermine ones' flexibility. Agreeableness, if not kept in proportion, could lead ones to prioritize others' needs over ones' own. Similarly, openness to experience could lead ones to become less focused and to engage in risky behaviors.

Personality Development

Nature vs. Nurture

A quest for the understanding of how personalities are developed has been long-standing. Previously, debates were made about which one was more influential: nature, pre-wired influences such as genetic inheritances or other biological factors, or nurture, external influences such as ones' upbringing, life experiences, or learning. However, such debates and extreme views draw less attention at present for it becomes evident that nature and nurture influences are not as distinguishable. Children are handed down genetic inclinations from their parents, who in turn provide them with their upbringing and home environments. Hence, their nature and nurture are interrelated. Similar interrelation applies given that ones' inborn inclinations (i.e., nature) could impact their subsequent environments (i.e., nurture). For example, infants with calm and easy temperament are likely to interact nicely and establish better interactions with their caregivers. These positive interactions, in turn, could reinforce their calm temperament. Hence, nature and nurture are intertwined; and their influences on personality development are intricate. Generally, nature is posited to be the foundation and sets up the limit for the degree to which nurture could subsequently influence personality development.

Psychological Grounds for Theory Development

1) The Genetic Approach

This approach explains personality development in relevance to genetic heredity, positing that genes play a significant role in personality development. Relevant research studies in this approach are generally based on twin studies. with the assumption that twins with more genetic similarity (i.e., identical/monozygotic twins) will have more in common in terms of personality than twins with less genetic similarity (i.e., fraternal/dizygotic twins).

Findings support the genetic influence on personality development. As shown in the PPT, positive correlations on the five personality dimensions of identical twins are stronger than those of the fraternal twins. These suggest that, when being compared, identical twins are more similar in terms of their personalities than fraternal twins. Additional support for this approach is drawn from case studies of identical twins who were separated early in life and raised apart. Despite the separation and different nurturance received, the twins are reported to maintain similarities in their personalities. These studies help support the influence of "nature" on personality development.

2) Psychosocial Development

Influenced by Freud's Psychosexual Theory of Personality Development, Erikson (1958, 1963) posited that personality develops in a predetermined order through eight stages, from infancy to adulthood. During each stage, ones have to resolve a psychosocial crisis in balancing their psychological needs and the demands from the society (e.g., their parents, school personnel, peers). If successfully resolved, ones will obtain a basic virtue to be developed in that particular stage. Then, ones will become better equipped and have a higher likelihood in resolving subsequent crisis(es) in the next stages.

Table 1: Erikson's Psychosocial Development

Stage	Age (Years)	Basic Virtue to Be Developed	Psychosocial Crisis	Description of the Crisis
1	0 - 1½	Hope	Trust vs. Mistrust	How consistent and reliable the care infants receive from their caregivers.
2	1½ - 3	Will	Autonomy vs. Shame	How much encouragement and support toddlers receive from their parents from their increased independence.
3	3 - 5	Purpose	Initiative vs. Guilt	How well young children are allowed to explore the world through initiating activities.
4	5 - 12	Competency	Industry vs. Inferiority	How much approval children receive in terms of demonstrating specific competencies valued by the society.
5	12 - 18	Fidelity	Identity vs. Role Confusion	How successful adolescents are in their identity search and achievement of their integrated sense of self.
6	18 - 40	Love	Intimacy vs. Isolation	How successful young adults are in forming intimate, loving relationships.
7	40 - 65	Care	Generativity vs. Stagnation	How well middle-aged adults could fulfill their needs to contribute to the society (e.g., mentoring younger generations, taking care of the elderly) and to bring about positive changes that will outlast themselves.
8	65+	Wisdom	Ego Integrity vs. Despair	How well mature adults feel integrated and view their lives as fulfilling and accomplished.

Whereas the theory is not free from criticism (e.g., the lack of clarity about the causes of development), it is well-recognized for explaining problems in personality development. Such problems could be used to explain unsuccessful resolutions of a relevant psychosocial crisis or a lack of proper virtue for subsequent development in later developmental stages.

As mentioned above, Erikson's Psychosocial Development Theory is influenced by Freud's Psychosexual Development Theory which also describes personality development in stages and posits that our mind consists of three key structures of psychic energy: (1) id, or the inborn, irrational and unsocialized energy/instinct aiming only for pleasure; (2) superego, or the social conventions learned through socialization; and (3) ego, or a component that seeks pleasure for id in accordance with the social conventions prescribed by superego.

3) Learning Approaches (Behaviorism)

Based on Behaviorism, these two approaches focus on outlining how ones' personalities, focused on their overt behaviors, are influenced and developed through their interactions with the environment.

3.1 Classical conditioning approach

In this approach, aspects of ones' personalities (e.g., reflexes, aversion, fears) are developed when ones make an association between two stimuli. The association results in a learned, not natural, response. An example is the salivation of a dog after hearing the tinkling sound of a keychain, after the sound is repeatedly paired with food. The process in which the association occurs can be divided into three phrases:

Phase 1 Before Conditioning: This phase involves a naturally occurring stimulus that automatically elicits a certain natural response without conditioning (i.e., manipulation). An example is the smell of food that naturally elicits the dog's reflexive response of salivation. Here, the food is the unconditioned stimulus (i.e., UCS) that naturally elicits the unconditioned response of salivation (i.e., UCR).

Phase 2 During Conditioning: This phase involves the pairing of a neutral stimulus (i.e., NS), or the keychain's tinkling sound which has no association with the salivation, with the aforementioned UCS (i.e., food). With repeated pairing, the association between the NS and the UCS is gradually formed (i.e., conditioned). Then, the NS, or the sound, becomes the conditioned stimulus (CS).

Phase 3 After Conditioning: Once the association is formed, the CS will signify the UCS (i.e., the sound signifies food). The CS alone could then elicit a response of salivation, even without the presence of UCS. Hence, simply hearing the keychain's tinkling sound, food is expected. As a result, the dog will salivate even without the presence of food. In this case, the salivation is not a natural response as it occurs through conditioning, and thus is considered the conditioned response (CR).

The understanding of the conditioning process helps explain some of our response tendencies, particularly our fear and anxiety. An example was illustrated in a study of a little boy who initially showed no fear of a white rat. However, after being exposed to a white rat which was paired repeatedly with loud, scary sounds, the boy became fearful of the white rat. The fear is also generalized to other fuzzy white objects. Another example is when ones become fearful of a dog or an airplane travel after a single pairing of these neutral stimuli with a frightening experience of being bitten by a fierce dog or a turbulence.

3.2 Operant conditioning approach

Based on Skinner's perspective, this approach proposes that certain aspects of our personality, particularly our behavioral tendencies, are developed due to their consequences in the environment. We are likely to increase our behaviors if such behaviors bring about positive outcomes (i.e., rewards). For instance, we are likely to increase our caring behaviors if doing so brings about compliments, tangible rewards, or good pride. Moreover, if such behaviors are reinforced repeatedly, they are more likely to become part of our personality and contribute to our agreeableness. In contrast, we are likely to decrease our behaviors if such behaviors result in negative consequences (i.e., punishments). For example, during early in life, if we were punished when trying to take initiative while

exploring new ways to play with toys, our openness to experience is likely to be less developed.

4. Social Cognitive Theory

Whereas this theory acknowledges the importance of environmental/social influences, it also highlights the role of our cognition in personality development. The cognition does not only involve our cognitive processes (e.g., attention, information processing, memory, decision-making), but also entails subsequent outcomes, namely, worldviews, values, and expectations.

An example comes from Bandura's classic Bobo doll study which showed that children learned to engage in certain behaviors based on their observation of a model (i.e., observational learning and modeling). In this experimental study, young children were exposed to a new toy, a Bobo doll, which they were unsure how to interact with, in two conditions. In the first condition, they were shown with the adults who played with the toy gently. In the second condition, the adults played with the toy aggressively. Findings indicated that children in both conditions imitated the behaviors of the adults as their role models when they were left to interact with the toy by themselves. While they learned from their observations, the degree to which the children could imitate the adults' interactions also depended on their cognitive capacities (i.e., how well they could memorize the interactions observed).

The role of cognition is significant as well when we decide whether to generalize what we observe. With regard to the Bobo doll illustration, our worldviews and values play an important role in our decision regarding how we will interact with the bobo doll as an adult. For instance, despite our observation of the aggressive model, if we value agreeableness and consider this as the key part of our personality, we are less likely to imitate the aggressive behaviors observed. In contrast, if one is less sympathetic, they are likely to be less hesitant to imitate those aggressive behaviors.

5. Humanistic Approach

This approach does not target the development of a particular aspect of personality. However, it outlines how well our overall personality develops, based on the Humanistic assumptions that individuals are endowed with their own unique potentials. As long as they are allowed to live their lives based on their potentials (i.e., fulfilling their self-actualization needs), one would flourish personality-wise and be able to contribute to the society in their own unique ways.

The aforementioned needs for self-actualization, however, could be at odds with the individuals' needs for positive regards (i.e., to be well-regarded and accepted) from their significant others. For instance, whereas ones might wish to fulfill their personal tendencies in being creative, they might have to subside or ignore their own needs in order to fulfill their significant others' expectations for them to conform and be traditional. The process could lead to the sense of self-discrepancies (i.e., individuals perceive a conflict in themselves) that prevent individuals from fully utilizing their creative potentials and obtaining the optimal personality development. In contrast, if the significant others allow the individuals to grow and develop in their own unique ways (i.e., providing them with unconditional positive regards), they are likely to be capable of utilizing their potentials to fully develop their personality.

Additional Resources

Research

1. The Big Five Traits as Predictors of Subjective and Psychological Well-Being
 - The relationships between the Big 5 personality traits and well-being (from both subjective and psychological perspectives)
 - <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.2466/PRO.105.1.205-231>
2. Theories of Personality
 - <https://rameliaz.github.io/files/course-materials/Theories%20of%20Personality.pdf>
3. Theoretical perspectives on the interplay of nature and nurture in personality development
 - A more comprehensive view of the interplay between genetic and environmental factors in personality development, such that inherited traits can influence individuals' selection of environment which, in turn, can determine changes in personality trait.
 - <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/B9780128046746000089>

Application

1. Understanding the Links Between Personality and Happiness
 - Research studies investigating the relationships between personality and well-being, and how this understanding can be applied to improve the quality of lives
 - <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/the-patterns-persons/202005/understanding-the-links-between-personality-and-happiness>
2. The Unexplored Differences Between Introverts and Extroverts
 - The nature of introverts and extroverts that are beyond just being quiet or sociable, and how this understanding can be applied in real life when working with other people.
 - <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/what-we-really-want-in-leader/202104/the-unexplored-differences-between-introverts-and>

3. Personality and Change: Is Our Personality Really Fixed?

- Understanding the dynamic view of personality and how we can promote personality change
- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/our-innovating-minds/202005/personality-and-change-is-our-personality-really-fixed>

Other sources

1. The Big 5 OCEAN Traits Explained - Personality Quizzes

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KCwHV9HCxH0>

2. Little Albert Experiment

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9hBfnXACsOI>

3. Bobo Doll Experiment

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dmBqwWUg8U>